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Lanny Morgan

Alto saxophonist Lanny Morgan was born on March 30, 1934 in DesMoines, Iowa. His family moved to Los Angeles in 1944 and he gained big band experience at Los Angeles City College. He worked locally and on the road with the bands of Charlie Barnet, Si Zentner and Terry Gibbs and in 1960 traveled to New York to join Maynard Ferguson's band. Lanny was one of the principal soloists with this group, recording frequently and touring Europe in 1962. He has led an active career in west coast studios while performing with Bill Berry, Ed Shaughnessy, Bill Holman and SuperSax.

Lanny was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 14, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Los Angeles. And this is a real pleasure for me to welcome the man with the meanest alto sound this side of Marshall Royal. Lanny Morgan. Welcome.

LM: Thank you. Thanks for having me. It's nice to be here.

MR: I recall hearing your sound on albums dating quite a while back so this is a pleasure.

LM: Well not too far now.

MR: Not too far, no. 1980.

LM: No the first recording I ever did was 1953 with the L.A. City College Jazz Band. We'd just won the *Metronome* — remember that magazine?

MR: Sure.

LM: You probably don't remember it but I know you've heard of it.

MR: I remember the name, yeah.

LM: They had a contest for the best college jazz dance band, and we won it. Sometimes I'm not sure why because Dave Baker, who has since become a very close friend of mine, his band was in it from Indiana and it was a wonderful band. Ours was more like a prom night band compared to that, but we did win it. We recorded four sides for Capitol records. They used to call them "sides" in those days.

MR: They weren't — well LPs — so you had how many, a total of eight songs or something?

LM: No four. No these weren't even LPs. These were 78s.

MR: Wow.

LM: Actually it amounted to two 78s, one tune on each side.

MR: They really were sides.

LM: Yes, that's right, that's it exactly.

MR: Were you guys playing like really high powered Kenton-type arrangements at that point?

LM: Well with that band you mean?

MR: Yeah.

LM: Actually it was the first lab band really I would say. Except you couldn't get a degree in that kind of music at the school. But it was the first band that played student arrangements and they had a recording studio, like a radio studio, it was called a radio and recording orchestra, or band. And Bob McDonald, who's since passed away, led that band and he would bring in ringers from town you know to help us out and to show us how they should be played. And he also had charts by some out of Stan's book and Woody's book and so forth. And it was really a good experience. Everybody wanted to be in it. I mean a lot of people from this town came out of that band.

MR: You started on the violin?

LM: Yes I did. Where do you get your information?

MR: Oh I have my sources.

LM: I started violin when I was six years old. My dad was a saxophone player in Des Moines, Iowa. He traveled around the midwest with the band and he also had the staff band of WHO and this was when Ronald Reagan was the, Dutch Reagan was the sportscaster. My dad, who loved him immensely said he didn't know anything about sports either. So anyway—

MR: At least he was consistent.

LM: He was. It just proves that a bad actor can be a bad president.

MR: Well whatever.

LM: But anyway my mother didn't want him to bring his horns home because it was still during the depression and there was a lot of carousing and drinking and wild women going on and she wanted her little boy to be something better than that. So he complied with her wishes. He never brought his horns home and practiced. But in the sixth grade I came home with a violin and so it started then. I was into it.

MR: But you were aware that — he didn't — did he play full time?

LM: Yeah.

MR: He played full time, wow. And plus he had the radio gig.

LM: Yeah. And then they played a lot of — oh there were places like the Kit Kat Club and the Belvedere Club and there were sort of like jazz places. And later on, after the violin episode they would take me to hear the band rehearse and things. So actually it was a very fruitful time for music because the pop stations were playing all the heavy bands. I mean you know Benny Goodman, Tommy Dorsey, Basie, Duke, they were all on what would be the rock & roll channels now. So it was great. A great experience to hear that.

MR: That was the popular music.

LM: Yeah.

MR: And his band, was it a big band or was it a combo?

LM: No it was three saxes, just three saxes, a trombone and three trumpets and three rhythm. And my uncle played saxophone in that band too so I sort of had — they were all my heroes, all those people.

MR: So the violin didn't last too long?

LM: Well it lasted 16 years.

MR: Oh, all right.

LM: But I started, what six years old, I guess it was the start of the first grade, but when I was in high school, about the eleventh grade there used to be a DJ out here named Gene Norman, who has since become a record producer, and he had a show called "The East Side Show" and it was all jazz. And of course that's the time that — the coast has always been big with Stan Kenton and Woody Herman because they were out here a lot of the time. But in addition to hearing that, Shorty had left Stan's band and so I heard all of Shorty Rogers and the Giants and all those things. And he was playing all the Miles Davis things, the "Birth of the Cool" and all the bebop from New York he would play, the older Fats Navarro and Howard McGhee and of course Bird and Monk and all those people. So I found myself walking to my violin lesson whistling "Groovin' High" and "Scrapple from the Apple." And so the violin didn't last too much longer after that. I had picked up the clarinet in junior high school. My dad gave me about a year's worth of lessons and so when I got to high school I was in the concert band, the marching band on clarinet, and the orchestra on violin. But as time went on, then I picked up the alto in the twelfth grade just before I got out of high school. And the violin began to go down the tubes after that.

MR: Did you have any aspirations of being a professional musician as a senior in high school?

LM: At the very end I did because actually I had a math/science major all through school. I was going to be a doctor but that didn't really go too well really. I wasn't — it just didn't appeal to me that much, the classes or the prospect of being in medicine really. So I was in all the all-city and all-state orchestras out here on violin, and they used to rehearse at City College. And we would get there sometimes, and Bob McDonald, who I didn't know then, would keep maybe the sax section or the brass section from his radio and recording orchestra over for a little section rehearsal. So we had to wait for them to get through. And one day I heard this — he had kept the sax section over and I heard that and it just blew me away and that was it. And I kept up the violin for a little while, I kept up the pretense I guess. But I mean actually I was a pretty good fiddle player. I'd gone through all the literature, never played professionally, but it was a little difficult to give it

up but the pull was so strong from what was called bebop at that time, that I couldn't fight it.

MR: Did your whole family come out to Los Angeles?

LM: I came out with my mother in 1944. They told me we were going out for a vacation, knowing that we were moving out here, which was a dirty trick. My dad was on the road back there for a while, and that sort of really didn't pan out because he joined us later but they separated soon after, eventually getting back together. So it was just my mother and I and her mother lived out here, and then eventually the whole clan moved out here, maybe about three or four years later.

MR: How did she feel about your direction you were going in as far as being, in essence, following your father's path. Is that the way she looked at it? I mean I'm assuming.

LM: Well I think that — you know times were a little different then. I did do my share of drinking and whatever else goes with the business. But you know the depression I think was kind of a really a hard time for people and you not only had not an awful lot of work, but there was a lot of bootlegging and things like that. A lot of hoods were around and it was just really a wild time all over. And if you were in the entertainment business it was, I would imagine, it was really like some of the movies you see. It was really kind of difficult to deal with, if you were the spouse of somebody who was doing that and waiting for them to come home and sometimes they did and sometimes they didn't. But my life was a little more structured and I always tried to keep that in mind, that I would really rather do something than fall off the ship in the middle of the ocean. And she saw it was serious too because when I went to City College I took not only the band but I was in the orchestra, I was in the woodwind, a couple of woodwind groups and I took harmony and counterpoint and arranging.

MR: So it was a more serious schooled approach that maybe she could relate to.

LM: Than my father had, yes.

MR: Charlie Barnet, was that your first name thing?

LM: Yes. That was very short. That was three weeks. But he was my first name band affiliation. And there was one chair open on that band and a friend of mine said, "why don't you try and go on this tour with us, it'll be a start and you'll meet some people" and so forth. So it was the fourth tenor chair, and I bought a tenor and I didn't — I've never had an affinity for the tenor. I've never even taken the time to find a decent mouthpiece until a few years ago, and then my tenor got run over by a TWA baggage cart and that was the end of that. And actually it was a tenor that Willie Maiden who was on Maynard's band with me had willed to me and it was a Vintage Mark VI. And I still have it and one day will get it fixed, but I don't like to play tenor. But I did in that band. There

was probably nobody that you would know — well maybe there was, Gary Frummer played drums, who later played with Art Pepper and Chet Baker, and bass player named Don Payne who moved to New York and went on to do some Brazilian type things. There was a tenor player, a wonderful tenor player named Charlie Deremal, who had taken Ted Nash's place with the original Billy May band, and he was a monster. And later for some reason he switched to alto for a while and played lead with Stan Kenton's band, which I still can't understand. But I don't think there's anybody else that you would know there. But it was just a three week thing. And a piano player named Ike Carpenter who you may have heard of, who had a band, a real screaming band out here for a lot of years, played piano in Charlie's band and at the end of the three weeks Charlie took sort of the nucleus of the guys that wanted to go of that band up to Lake Tahoe and we stayed there for the summer, for three months, at the Calvada which was right up from the Cal Neva. I don't know if you're familiar with Lake Tahoe or not. But that was a nice little gig. It only paid $120 a week and you had to pay for your own lodging and food. So the only thing that happened from that, rewarding, for me, was that I found a dentist up there and had all the work done on my teeth and I came home with oh I don't know $150 I guess.

MR: Well you got a little taste of it, you know, big band, you were what 20 years old?

LM: Yeah. Twenty years old and we also played behind, you know Nat Cole came in for three weeks, Mel Torme, and we backed them up and we got to know them pretty well, and I mean just playing behind Nat for three weeks was worth the whole summer actually for me. And some acts that were not so enduring like Gogi Grant maybe and people of that — good but not the kind that are going to last forever.

MR: So at least you decided well I am going to still pursue this. It didn't knock you out of the thought of doing it.

LM: No because I did meet people and there were plans — you know you'd meet somebody and I'm sure you know how that is too. People say hey you know, so-and-so's going out in two weeks. And it was mostly all road work at that time because the studios at that time weren't really employing doublers, not many doublers if any. They were all straight flute players, straight oboe players, straight this player and so forth. And they were all on staff, Paramount and MGM and Twentieth Century. So there was not even any thought of that. So it was all, you know there were maybe 40, 45 bands in this country that you could think about going with. The Dorseys and Benny Goodman and —

MR: Yeah. I guess I had this fairly misconstrued idea that the big bands almost like disappeared in the latter 40s.

LM: No I think they – they weren't as hot as they were. But I think the big bands didn't — well I think they were really almost over at the end of the 50s. Because both Dorseys were alive then. Benny was still alive then. Even the bands like Henry Busse and bands that people really didn't want to go out with but they would to get road experience. But when I was on Maynard's band in the 60s, the first half of the 60s, we used to play dances and there was standing room only. And there were a lot of kids too, which was amazing. I wish it was that way today.

MR: Yes. Did the prospect of the draft frighten you?

LM: Well it did. Actually I'll take a minute and a half and tell you this story. I'm trying to think of the timeframe. I went to City College actually because I wanted to go to City College, but probably a lesser reason was that the Korean War was going on then too and I really didn't want to go for that. So I couldn't just go to City College and take music. You had to prepare for a teacher's credential to make it legitimate. So to do that I had to take a lot of subjects that I had had a bellyful of in high school like English and sciences and history and things that really didn't interest me at all but I did it because I wanted that education, because I really didn't want to go to Korea. But my grades were so bad in the academic subjects that they finally flunked me out and I went on the road in 1954, and just stayed out of school and figured I'd take my chances. And then I got a call from Bill Perkins in San Francisco. He was on Stan's band then, and he said would you like to come on the band, Lennie Niehaus is going to leave. And I said I'd love to, because that's the band that Bill Holman was writing for, and I ate and slept that band, it was a wonderful band. And I said yes. And he said well just sit tight, it shouldn't be too long. Well he called in another month and said Lennie's decided to stay for a while. In the meantime I had to make some money so I joined Frankie Carle's band. Remember that band?

MR: Yeah.

LM: Well there was a three-month tour with that band to mostly the southwest. And I went on that tour and we were playing Texas A&M and a cadet came up with a note from my parents and it said, "Lanny call home regarding induction notice."

MR: Ouch.

LM: So they gave me a couple of months to finish the tour and settle my affairs, and then I went in the Army I think March '57 and then I got out New Year's Eve in 1958. So it took a big chunk out which I regretted. I mean I think something could have happened to my career faster had I had that opportunity then. But actually my time in the service was mostly in Europe with the Seventh Army Symphony and we played a couple of soldier shows which are like Broadway shows that they send around to the different Kacernes

they call them in Germany, and then we had a jazz show, an 18-piece jazz band that did six months over there. And I couldn't have been any more fortunate. Along with myself it was Eddie Harris and Leo Wright and Don Ellis and Cedar Walton. So it was really playing with good musicians and also the outside playing — we used to go to Heidelberg and play at The Cave, it was a jazz joint there. And then I played with the Symphony too, we did "Porgy and Bess" and another Gershwin thing. So it wasn't time wasted, it was just dead time as far as what I really wanted.

MR: Yeah you were off the scene.

LM: Yeah, exactly. Why didn't I think of that? You said it in three words.

MR: The Ferguson band seemed to be one of the hottest things going. That was 13 pieces? Thirteen, 14?

LM: Thirteen pieces. Well I think it was. I may be a little prejudiced. I think at times during that particular band's lifetime, which was probably 1957 through when he left New York which was early '66, I think that band was maybe four, five times — nobody could touch it. It was the hottest band in the world, and I'm including everybody. Actually I played with that band in 1957 before I went in the service. Willie Maiden was an old friend of mine. And he was playing baritone on the band and he got sick one night, they were playing a place called Peacock Lane in L.A. This was when L.A. had jazz places. And so I went up and subbed for him for two nights. And then when I got out, Jimmy Ford was on the band. Jimmy later became a very good friend of mine. But he left the band. Well I spent a year in L.A. and then I got a call from Willie in March 1960 he said that Jimmy was leaving and would I want to join the band. And I really did have to think about it a little bit because I was starting to do a little studio work out here and doing some pretty good gigs. I was recording with Si Zentner's band, I was working a lot with the new Terry Gibbs band and some other people. So it took me about three or four days and I called him back and moved back. And you know the day I got there we had a rehearsal at a place called Lynn Oliver's, at 89th and Broadway. And I was staying with Willie Maiden. And we came home from the rehearsal and my dad called and said, "Lanny, Stan wants you to come on the band."

MR: Get out.

LM: I'm serious. And I couldn't do it. Because I moved, I like to say lock, stock and barrel to New York. I didn't have that much then, I was, well it was right around my 26th birthday. But I had canceled everything out there and moved to New York. And then he wanted me to come on the band. So I had to turn him down. So it was really a drag. But the band then, I have to say that I did the right thing. Because, talking about Maynard's band again, I think Stan's band never really achieved what it once was. Maybe after 1957 I

don't think it was ever that again. And Maynard's band was on the rise and it was a hot band and it just kept getting better and better. And so many guys went through that band. You know the saxes when I joined were Frank Hittner was playing baritone and Joe Farrell was playing tenor and Willie and myself. Slide Hampton was on the band quite a bit off and on, Jackie Byard, and then a lot of other guys came through the band too at different times.

MR: Were you there when Don Menza came through?

LM: Yeah. Don replaced Joe Farrell. It was Joe and then Menza and then Frank Vicari was the third tenor player. And then the band broke up, not because of that, but shortly after that.

MR: What was the travel situation like, the road? Was it a tough grind in those days?

LM: Yes. Looking back at it you forget all those things. But — it was a wonderful experience but I wouldn't want to do it again. Yeah, because we had — we didn't have a bus, we had station wagons. And starting salary on that band was $120 a week. I made $135 because I was not only the lead alto player but played a lot of jazz toodon and because he'd known me. And so $135 a week and he had two station wagons and then he drove himself, he had two jaguars — a Mark IX that never ran more than three or four blocks at a time, and that little white XKE or the predecessor to the XKE I guess. But I wound up driving one of the station wagons, and a friend of mine from Maine, Don Doane wound up driving the other one. And well you can imagine, if you have a one-nighter in Chicago, I just found a pay receipt for this the other night, it was for $23.65, a one-nighter in Chicago. Now out of that tax was taken, so you get about $19.00. Out of that you have to pay for your own lodging and for food, so we used to stay at the Croyden Hotel in Chicago, that was like $2.50 a night, another 50 cents if you wanted a black & white T.V. And say another six dollars for food maybe. So in other words you're coming home with $11.00, $11.50. So I took the driving job because we got one cents a mile. Well now Chicago is 960 miles, so I would come home with an extra $18, or a little over $19, plus my $11, would be 30 bucks I would have see?

MR: Yeah. Gee that was like an extra night of work.

LM: That's right. When I joined that band we rehearsed that day, the day I got back there, and the next day we opened at Birdland. And we opened for some reason, it seems like we played there for three weeks. Birdland usually booked people for two weeks but this was three weeks. And it was opposite Art Blakey, the band with Wayne Shorter and Lee Morgan and Curtis Fuller.

MR: Curtis Fuller? That sounds right.

LM: A good band. And then we went right away, we had one day off and we went to the Brooklyn Paramount and we played there opposite the Jazztet, the newly formed Jazztet, Art Farmer and—

MR: Benny Golson.

LM: Benny Golson and also another hot — King Curtis was on there, do you remember him?

MR: King Curtis was on that band?

LM: No, not on the band but he was there. I don't know if Jack McDuff was there or not, but I think they were together at that time. And that was another good show. That was for ten days. And then we had about four gigs on the road — Pennsylvania, yeah, around Philly, in that area. And then, and I thought, this is wonderful. What is that, like 135 times 5 almost. I'm rolling. I was paying $155 a week for a place at 85th and Broadway in Manhattan and I thought I'd died in gone to heaven. Then we didn't work for a month and a half see, and nobody was on retainer. Nobody was on a retainer. Everything was pro-rated when we did work. So the reality set in there. Because then I really went from wealthy to poor in about five weeks. But the driving was terrible. I'll be brief about this, I'm spending too much time with the driving, but I'd set out like at 8:00 at night from, we used to leave from Junior's or Charlie's Tavern at 52nd and Broadway, to go to Chicago or even Pittsburgh or some place, and it would be snowing so hard you couldn't see somebody standing as close to me as you are, and have to drive all that way, and usually we'd leave late so we could catch the day sheet, which meant you'd check in about six in the morning and you'd grab a few hours sleep, and then you'd leave right after the gig and come back to New York to save money.

MR: I didn't quite follow — the day sheet?

LM: Well the day sheet begins usually at 6 or 7:00 in the morning. In other words that's that day.

MR: Are you talking about a hotel?

LM: A hotel.

MR: Okay.

LM: It's like this hotel ends, and they don't want you to leave until eleven or noon maybe. But their sheet for new people checking in begins at probably seven or eight o'clock in the morning, if they have any rooms available then. So we would try and catch that and get a good day's sleep and then leave after the job and drive all the way back to New York which was difficult.

MR: You mean you drove to Chicago for a one-nighter?

LM: Oh yeah. Several times.

MR: Boy, I thought the rock & roll business was something.

LM: No we did that quite a few times. We played Chicago and places like that.

MR: And probably the thruway system, the roads were a long way from where they are now.

LM: The thruways and the turnpikes were finished, but the interstates were not. And of course although we got reimbursed for tolls, it took time to stop and go through the toll booths all the time. And when you're on a roll, you know I couldn't drink during that period. I had to stay sober. Because driving through a blizzard with these guys— but you just get on a roll and you want to go. It's kind of hypnotic, and I really shouldn't have done that. But we would try these new interstates and they were a drag because you'd take an interstate for a hundred miles and you'd think oh this is wonderful, and they were brand new roads and so forth. And then it would say "END." End of interstate. Merge into one lane. So you'd come into one lane and then it would take you probably an hour and a half to get back to a decent road. Because the interstates, if you notice on a map sometimes, go way far off of the freeways or the thruways. So that part of it was a drag, and there were some places like Cincinnati that it was almost impossible to get to. There were no decent roads. There were like a lot of two lane highways, back woods gas stations where you were almost afraid to stop sometimes, we had a couple of carloads of kids follow us into a gas station in West Virginia once and they had chains. You know they were going to get us good. Fortunately our car was newer and we got out of there fast. But there was a lot of that really. It was not completely safe to be traveling, even with six guys in the car.

MR: Did you have a mixed — was that a mixed band?

LM: Yes.

MR: Black and white?

LM: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have any trouble? Well you said down in the—

LM: Well we didn't have any trouble, we just had to, we couldn't stay at the same hotels. I remember Richmond, Virginia, Jackie Byard and Rufus Jones were on the band, and we had to take them to a colored hotel, and then we came back to ours. And of course they could eat there at their own hotel, but when we were traveling down south, you had to go into like a diner and bring them something to go. And Chet Feretti, who was the lead trumpet player when I first joined the band, an Italian and a dark-skinned Italian, and I was like a southern California beach boy at that time, where even in New York I found the beach right away and got a tan as much as I could. They wouldn't serve us in a restaurant in I think it was either Delaware or Maryland, down the coast from New York, because they said we were too dark. And I had my license, and I said, "wait a minute," I said, "look here, it says Caucasian." And he said, "I don't care what it says," he said,

"you ain't gettin' no food here." And it was a drag, because we were getting food for the rest of the guys in the car too see? So we just had to keep going until we found some more hospitable people.

MR: Were you infuriated by that?

LM: Well I was infuriated, and it's a little frightening sometimes too because you never know where it's going to come from. New York was so open and so integrated, and California was too, but you know you get in the back woods of some of these southern states, and at that time, in my opinion, the state troopers were just as bad as the other people with their old cavalry hats and their boots up to here and they were real hotshots, real rednecks. So if you got stopped — I mean they would stop you for no reason at all. We got stopped several times on that band just because there were a mixed group in the car.

MR: "Hi we're the Maynard Ferguson band." That'd cut a lot of slack, wouldn't it?

LM: Say what? Youza what? But they didn't — nothing ever happened to us down there except almost that incident with the kids and the chains, but once in Pennsylvania coming home from oh Pittsburgh I think, or maybe even Chicago, because I was dead tired and I was driving, and the speed limit was 65 and I was 65 right on the button. It didn't have cruise control, but I just had my foot right there and I hadn't budged for miles. And a state trooper pulled up next to me and I just looked at him and kept driving, because I wasn't breaking the law. Well he eventually pulled me over and told me I was speeding, and I said, "no I wasn't, I've been going 65." And of course you can't argue with those people. You know he made everyone get out of the car, and everybody was half asleep or juiced or whatever, it was a strange — and I thought here we go, boy this will be 99 years in the electric chair for all of us. But he let us go with a very stern warning, and we poured everybody back in the car and went back, and I went about 60 all the way home.

MR: Well you guys put some good stuff on wax.

LM: Yeah. No one was ever really happy about it.

MR: Really? Was it too rushed?

LM: Well the band, I mean we always thought it was poorly recorded. But they sent me a request for some comments on that Mosaic CD, and I sent it to them and they sent me a set of them as payment, gratitude, whatever, which I thought was wonderful. I don't know if they re-mastered those or not, but I thought everybody came out very well.

MR: Carmen Leggio was on that.

LM: Not with me. He was on before me.

MR: Before you.

LM: Yeah, but Carmen was a good player. I was familiar with what he did. That band was a lot of fun. You know it was a very loose band, and people used to accuse it of being loud

and out of tune, but it really wasn't. It had moments when it probably was, but most of the time it was a pretty sensitive band, and the guys all got along most of the time. But it was something that I'm glad I did. I don't know if I'd want to — well I know I wouldn't want to repeat it at my age now, but it was something that I'm glad I did.

MR: Yeah. Good to be a part of it. You came back, was it a conscious decision to come back and get into studio work on your part or did you just kind of fall into it?

LM: Well I didn't really, I didn't have a thought of ever coming back to Los Angeles. But you know things had fallen to almost zero in New York. Maynard left in 1966 and I had a little group with Mike Abene and Ronnie McClure, Antonio Zalocco and a trumpet player named Dick Hurwitz, had a little quintet, and we made a demo, we had made a demo earlier, before the band broke up that I couldn't sell, and I still have it, it's a good demo, it really is. But I took it to Neshui Ertegun once on a cold winter's night and he gave me this jive about how the company didn't have any money and he had his feet on the desk and was talking on the phone while he was listening to my platter, you know it was like a pancake style. And he said he didn't have any money and the next couple of weeks they released some of the worst horseshit that I ever heard in my life. But that was my introduction to the record business. You know you don't just bring them something good and say, "I'd like to have you do this," because there's more to it than that. But anyway that fell through and that was kind of discouraging. And then I was doing some jingles in New York. Mike Abene had gotten a little bit into the jingle end of it writing for them and he got me in on some of those, just a little bit of this and that, some record dates. I was working at a supper club in Mineola, Long Island that took up the slack. I mean I had a deal there where if I wasn't working I could always go in there and do it, and that was good for three or four nights a week. I had probably 30 private students and I drove to their house and that really broke my back, that was really difficult.

MR: Wow. This was in New York?

LM: In New York, on Long Island. And I charged, I worked for a company and they charged them $5.00 and out of that I got $3.50. So I mean what is that, thirty students, if I taught them all in a week, that was 90, a little less than a hundred dollars. And then I started to work a gig, the Copacabana opened up and I took that for about the last nine months I was in New York. But you know even the jazz thing kind of folded it seemed like. I was on a band that Howard McGhee put together for a couple of years. And we used to play festivals and things. We rehearsed at that church that the Reverend Gensel had on Fifth Avenue was it or Madison?

MR: I don't know.

LM: I just heard he died a few months ago or last year. But there really wasn't anything there that was doing me any good career-wise. And a friend of mine who I'd gone to school with who was in that band at City College, named Jules Chaikin, called me. We had remained friends all those years and he said, "how are you doing there?" And I said, "well I'm doing fine." And he asked me what I was making, just like that. And I said, "well I'm making maybe six-fifty a week." And he said, "well that's not bad," but he said, "you know I can do better for you." He said, "if you're ever going to come back to California," he said, "do it now." And he explained it to me. And so my then-wife and I talked it over and I did go back out. And I'll tell you I went back about the same time I left, almost nine years to the day, and in the remaining nine months of that year I made probably more than I had in the last three years in New York, just doing studio things. It was roaring out here then, it was just so busy it was incredible. And people would sandwich dates. You would like accept something and then you would have to send a sub in to cover the first part of that date or the last part of the last one. It was just all day long it was like this, sometimes from eight in the morning until midnight.

MR: T.V. and film and commercials, and just anything.

LM: Yeah. Records. But a lot of them, my niche, they kind of put you where they want you, and my niche was live television. And so I did all the, well I did part of "The Joey Bishop Show," "The Della Reese Show," "The Tony Orlando and Dawn Show," all the Chuck Barris things, "The Gong Show," "The $1.98 Beauty Show" "Dinah Shore," I can't even think of all of them. But people used to put down live television because sometimes the music was so bad — well no not the music bad, but you just sat around all day long. Like "The Gong Show," we would rehearse maybe 75 acts, short, and then we would do five shows on Saturday and five shows on Sunday. There was a lot of sitting around because they go so fast you know. Some of those people you know they'd just throw them right off. But see then you get residuals from that. The first re-run is 75%, the next one is a little less and so forth, ad infinitum. So I didn't see anything wrong. The only trouble is that there is no live television anymore as you can see. Most everything is faded except film. And the guys that got into film and stayed with it are still working, most of them. Film never appealed to me really because I don't think you can have as much fun with film because it's too exact. You know some of these people write things like, well I remember I went in to cover a date for Ted Nash, not young Ted but his uncle. Not the Ted Nash in New York, but his uncle, who was a tenor player before him. He became one of the first-call lead players out here, which entails soprano, alto, pic, flute, alto flute, bass flute sometimes, E flat clarinet, B flat clarinet and sometimes bass clarinet. And this date was at the old Columbia picture studio which is on Sunset Boulevard and Gower.

And I walked in there and they wanted him to stay to do this one take and he did, and thank God he did it because there was nobody, I mean it was just him all by himself and he started on a high F on soprano, triple piano, just bing. And I realized then, I don't want to do this. I really don't have the time to keep that up on those horns to make it my life's work to do it. And I feel that way today too, I don't want to do that kind of work. You know you die.

MR: That's high pressure.

LM: Yeah, it's too much pressure for me. I don't care for it. But I got embroiled in that and I'm glad I came back for that part of it, although it's died out now, but I've always missed New York. And every time I go back there I take a nostalgia walk around and see where the old Birdland was, which is now a girlie joint, and the Metropole is a girlie joint, and some of those places aren't even there anymore, the Five Spot and — but I think the thing that I really miss about New York is the New York of the 60s and not New York, especially the way it is now.

MR: Well I wanted to play a couple of things that you've played on if you don't mind —

LM: Is this going to be painful for me?

MR: No, I don't think it is. I think they're pretty darn good myself.

[audio interlude]

LM: This has got to be live at the Concord.

MR: That is a mouthful.

LM: Well that's Marshall playing lead you know.

MR: Yeah.

LM: That was a good record. It really was a good record. I think one of the best parts about that record was Richie Kamuca, who I've always been a big fan of Richie's. And of course Marshall too, and I think Blue was on that too, wasn't he? Didn't Blue do, wasn't Blue Mitchell on that?

MR: Actually this recording is from, I think it's a live—

LM: Yeah. It's called "Hello Rev."

MR: Yeah, "Hello Rev" yeah.

LM: But it was done live at Concord. But it was a good band.

MR: What was Marshall Royal like? Was he an exacting straw boss?

LM: Well he was a straw boss, you got that right. I don't know, I love Marshall. Marshall never really dictated, Marshall did it the way a real lead player should do it, and it's the way I've always advocated. You shouldn't have to tell people anything. You just play it the way you want it and they should follow you. And that's what he did. And everybody had enough respect for him that they did it. To be very honest with you I didn't agree

with everything Marshall played. I mean the way he played is not my style of playing. And I didn't listen to him that much when I was a kid, I was listening to other people and a little, you know like maybe Bud Shank at that time or Vinnie Dean or Lee Konitz, that kind of thing he did with Stan or even the tenor players with Woody's band. But I knew what Marshall was and what he had done and I certainly would have done anything he wanted me to do, to play with him in that regard. And we were good friends and we got along very well and it was a nice relationship. But I've got to tell you a funny story. When I was still on Maynard's band, this was about 1961, we used to rehearse at Birdland. And Maynard called a 4:00 rehearsal. Well Basie had called a 1:00 rehearsal. So I got there a little early and Basie's band was still rehearsing. Well Frank Wess was playing second alto then. I don't know if you remember that configuration. But I think it was Billy Mitchell and Frank Foster were playing the other two tenors. But Frank Wess didn't show up so Marshall said, "you want to come over here and play a couple of tunes with us to finish out the rehearsal?" I said, "sure." So I went up and played with them and we played through this thing, it was sort of mediocre. And Ernie Wilkins had brought this chart in. Well now Ernie Wilkins is the one that wrote "Geller's Cellar" which later became "Morgan's Organ" that I recorded with Maynard's band. But it was originally written for Herb Geller. But anyway we got through playing this and Marshall looked at Ernie, standing right in front of the band and he said, "Ernie, who wrote this piece of shit?" And Ernie says, "what do you mean, Marsh," he said, "I wrote it. What's wrong with it?" Marshall said, "Ernie, that's the worst piece of crap I ever heard, man." He said, "who wrote this, Ernie?" And Ernie said, "I wrote it." Marshall says, "I'll be God damned if you wrote it." That's the only time I ever — now I never knew who did it, but I've got a hunch Marshall was right. He didn't have time and he farmed it out to somebody. Maybe he had a kid, one of his students or something write it and played him a couple of bucks and took it in. But Marshall nailed him right away. And he would do that. He became a little more mellow in his older years. But he was a funny guy. And he and Rabbit [Johnny Hodges] they used to play the same way. They'd play with their eyes open, and they'd play something that was hot you know, something that they thought would get all the ladies and so forth, and then they'd go — and they'd kind of look all around like this. It's really wild to watch. It's that school.

MR: Yeah. I can see Johnny Hodges doing that. I didn't know Marshall did that.

LM: Marshall did it too. It was very funny. I used to watch them and I wouldn't crack up but I would inside.

MR: Hey — I'll have to try that someday.

LM: But you know I play lead sometimes with Bill's band when I can be here now, and I've told Bill up front, I wouldn't try and, you don't even try to play those things the way Marshall did. It's a whole different style. He played "Warm Valley" and the thing we're going to play tonight "Isfa —" It's a thing written for Johnny Hodges ["Isfahan"]. But all those things that are synonymous with either Johnny Hodges or Marshall, there's no point in anyone trying to do that. That's not the way I feel them, and I mean I can get them off reasonably well but it's still not the same thing. I don't even remember the question you asked. Oh you asked me about Marshall. He was a great guy. He really was a great guy.

MR: Okay, one more little finger buster here.

[audio interlude]

LM: Oh it's "Koko." SuperSax.

MR: I mean that's impossible.

LM: You know which album this is from?

MR: L.A. Voices. Number 3.

LM: Oh this is where Med sings. Does Med sing on this?

MR: Yeah, I don't think I got that far. That is just I mean outrageous.

LM: It is. I'll tell you, of course Med always wants to kill me. Med or Nimitz want to kill me when I say this but the lead part or the baritone part are the easiest parts. The second alto and the two tenor parts are just a bear. And if I'd known you were going to do that I'd have brought you a copy of the second alto part. In fact, maybe I'll send it to you.

MR: I'd love it. Because I know what you're saying because all those lower harmonies and stuff, and when they write the arrangements they're not necessarily taking into account —

LM: Med does. Med does all the writing. Well he did, Buddy Clark did some and Warne Marsh did some. Med never writes a repeated note, and for some reason he doesn't use too many scales. I don't know why he doesn't do that because they're usually kind of easy to voice and to play on. Or diminished chords. But even with that, I mean in other words he'll cross voice, rather than repeat a note. But they're still hard, they're really hard.

MR: How much time would you have to get that ready?

LM: Well I wasn't on the original SuperSax. It was Bill Perkins first and then Joe Lopes, the first couple of years. They spent a year rehearsing in Perk's garage before they even ventured outside. But see the band doesn't work anymore, that's the trouble. So Med's got a band, a big band, with seven or eight brass and the sax is SuperSax in front, and then the L.A. voices too. Well that's like a 19-piece band, and it's hard to even book a trio in this town let alone a 19 piece band. So he's put all his effort into that for the last

several years. As a result SuperSax is not working, not doing anything. When we were working quite a bit, even three or four times a month, this stuff was easy. But I mean well it was not easy but everyone had it under their fingers, even the inner parts. But you know we'll get a gig now and Med will call maybe a three-hour rehearsal and we'll go over some of these things, but you can't begin to get all those things. I mean it's not only this, there's a whole host of those things that are really very difficult. Even the slow ones are hard.

MR: Even what?

LM: Even the slow ones. Some of the ballads, "Lover Man" is impossible, only because the saxes have to lay behind the time so far, like Bird did. "Embraceable You."

MR: Yeah. So it's not just a finger thing, it's a whole concept of where's the time.

LM: And if you don't know Bird, it's just — you know you really have to know Bird to play that, to know the way he played it.

MR: Could you pick out of the things you've made, your recollection of a personal favorite solo or a recording that you really are glad you did?

LM: Of my own or with a band?

MR: Yeah, of your own.

LM: Well I wrote a couple of things out with the quartet that I like. One of them is on VSOP it's just called "The Lanny Morgan Quartet," and the other one is after that and it's on Contemporary and it's called "Pacific Standard." I like those two, and some of those things with the big band. I like the thing we did called "Tinsel" with Maynard's band. That was Willie's favorite thing that he ever wrote I think. And it's a ballad, I think I just played a chorus or two of this kind of altered blues thing, but I just kind of liked the way that came together.

MR: I wanted to read something. These are two different quotes about you, and it caught my eye because one is from the *Grove Encyclopedia of Jazz* and it's talking about you and then, "he has few peers on 'Cherokee'." And then there's another thing from another book about recordings, it says, "'Cherokee' is a song he practically owns." What's this thing with "Cherokee" now?

LM: Well you know when I was coming up, "Cherokee" was something you had to conquer, much like — now my memory is leaving me, I'm having a senior moment — no you know like "Giant Steps" — much like "Giant Steps" was a couple of decades later. There are tunes like that floating around, like "Cherokee," "Giant Steps," "Stella By Starlight," things that have a lot of changes and move around. So I worked hard on that, and I recorded it first with Maynard on "The New Sounds of Maynard Ferguson," and then I recorded it probably three times on my own, not all of them intentionally. I recorded

"Koko" on an album I did for Palo Alto Records and I recorded "Cherokee" on that VSOP album, and then I just did one that's supposed to come out on that Fresh Sounds, that Spanish label out of Barcelona, that's called "A Suite for Yardbird," they're all Bird tunes, and I did "Koko" again because the producer wanted me to do it, so who am I to argue with the producer so I did it. So I guess I played it so much. I don't really claim to be the master of "Cherokee," there's a lot of people that — I mean anybody who's proficient on the horn plays it well usually but I think one of those quotes was from Scott Yanow. But it's just a tune I played a lot I think.

MR: Well it caught his ear anyway.

LM: Well, whatever it takes.

MR: Yeah. Well what's in the near future for you, besides your playing with Bill Berry tonight?

LM: Well you know I've been traveling with Natalie Cole for the last six and a half years. In fact we just got back from the east coast with her a couple of weeks ago. I'm going to Elmhurst College around Chicago to do a jazz weekend, Mike Abene and myself and Bobby Shew and Maynard and the band is going to be there too, so that's from the 25th of this month through the end of the month. And then she has some things throughout the year, one of them will be in Brazil I think for about three weeks, going to England in April with a small group. Do you know Vic Lewis? Have you ever heard of Vic Lewis?

MR: I guess I haven't.

LM: Vic had a big band in London and now he's sort of an entrepreneur. He's bringing this small group over. This will be Pete Christlieb, Bill Perkins, myself, Carl Saunders, Ron Stout, Andy — don't do this Lanny — the trombone player, a wonderful trombone player — Martin, Andy Martin, a young guy. Have you heard of any of those people?

MR: Some of them. Pete Christlieb for sure.

LM: Okay. So we're going to do one night in London with a small band and the next night with Bill Holman's band, he's going to use us who are in the band anyway and supplement it with English players. And then he's going — Phil Woods did a tour with a big band starting in Spain for a guy named Jordi Pujol who's a booker over there. He's a friend of Jordi Sunol, who has Fresh Sounds records. I may have those last names mixed up, but anyway we've got about five or six dates over there with Bill's band over there. I think the North Sea Festival and a couple of dates in Portugal and things like that, and also I have a few things of my own, some involve traveling and some are in town.

MR: Yeah. You do your own booking? Your own business?

LM: Yeah, my wife helps me with that. My wife's a publicist.

MR: That helps.

LM: And she helps me when she can but it's very difficult. I think you really need a high powered booking agent. It's like when Maynard started he had Joe Glaser from ABC Booking and the way Maynard got started was that Joe would call these people and say, "you want Miles in there for a couple of weeks?" And they'd say, "yeah, I'd love to have him." "Well how about Maynard Ferguson?" "No, never heard of him." And Joe would say, "if you want Miles, you'll take Maynard too." And they got him. Of course Joe and a lot of these bookers also were capable of putting people face down in the local river if they had to, too. That was kind of a hold over from the depression I think. But now there's so many people that want to work, that want to do things, and if you look, you being a saxophone player and a musician, if you look out there you can see that some of them deserve to be working and some of them don't. It's a crap shoot really, and it's not so much gee I play good or I want to work a lot or I want to record a lot, a lot has to do with this or who you know and so forth. So that's just the way it is.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure talking with you.

LM: It's been my pleasure, and I'm sure you found out that I'm a real motor mouth once you get me started.

MR: Yeah, absolutely.

LM: But I enjoyed it, I appreciate your having me.

MR: I'm looking forward to hearing the band tonight. And best of luck in your travels.

LM: You take care. I hope we see each other again sometime.

MR: All right.